Those were trying times for the country. Pakistan stood polarized. On the one hand, Nawaz Sharif's juggernaut had taken over Punjab, with a massive majority in the 2013 elections. Opposition leader Imran Khan had managed to win only one out of the four provinces, and wasn't doing too well. He claimed Nawaz had cheated. Nobody – not the courts, not the media, not the people – bothered to do anything about his complaints. So, he put a rag-tag coalition together and decided to march upon Islamabad. The momentum and number of supporters he required to paralyse the capital, he never got. So, he started talking to the media and pulling these interesting political stunts. Every night, for three months, as he stayed parked outside Parliament on a container, he would make some controversial speech or the other or pull a stunt. And then, one monsoon night, as he stood there with millions watching, he invited me to join him. The issue was so loaded and the country so politicized that all of a sudden, I started getting calls – from news channels, from politicians, from family members – advising me to go or not to go. The fate of the country hung in the balance with Khan's anti-Nawaz sit-in.

I decided to opt out. No doubt, Imran bhai is quite the leader. But there are a lot of people in his Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf whom he doesn't need. His dependence on these people scared me off from joining him. See, he's *the* Khan. He doesn't need anyone, especially not turncoats. He needs fresh blood. He needs the youth. But a lot of people are misusing his name for their own benefit. Now that he's PM, I'm hoping his party's internal accountability has improved.

As for Mian Nawaz Sharif sahib, I'm not going to get into the Panama Leaks or the other investigations that were underway against him by the time this book went to print. But there is no doubt – and my opinion here may raise quite a few eyebrows – that Mian sahib knows how to deliver.

Look at Karachi, Peshawar and Quetta, the capitals of the three provinces he's never governed. They are suffering. Look at Lahore, the province of Punjab which he governed. It's not. That's my argument.

As for the mighty Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, which is Imran Khan's territory, his party's done well there but still has a long way to go. He should follow the simple political principle of what is seen, is then sold. I want delivery for all provinces. Imran bhai hasn't gotten there yet.

So, yes. I admit it. I love Pakistani politics. I try to keep an eye on it. When I'm at home, I'm obsessed with catching the news and browsing through talk shows. Sure, they get dramatic at times. But the media is important. Pakistan matters to me. Naturally, Pakistan's politics matters too.

I know a lot of sportsmen steer clear of the potholes on the rocky road of public policy and politics. But I can't put a blindfold on and not notice and care about what needs to change. People in my position need to care. We need to give support to the needy. It is because of the people of this country that I am where I am. Yes, I enjoy my status but I refuse to live in a bubble. For the sake of the people. Politics or no politics, I will strive to work for the people of Pakistan. That's where my foundation, the Shahid Afridi Foundation (SAF), comes in.

Of all recent leaders, I've been most impressed by General (retired) Raheel Sharif. He was one of those stand-up-and-be-counted guys. Always ready to deliver. In his historic tenure as army chief – and that *is* a controversial office in Pakistan – people went crazy for him because he made some very tough decisions. He started off with an in-house change. He cleaned up the army. Then he went for the terrorists in North Waziristan, Balochistan and Karachi. That's why he had